

Cave art

People began painting on cave walls at least 35,000–40,000 years ago, during the Stone Age. This 9,000-year-old example is from the Cueva de las Manos (Spanish for the Cave of the Hands) in Argentina. The forest of what appear to be waving hands was created by blowing paint around each hand, like making a stencil. Sometimes figures were engraved on soft cave walls with flint tools. Mineral pigments were used to make paint. Iron oxide gave a red color, manganese oxide or charcoal provided black, and other minerals added yellow and brown. Cave art techniques included painting with the fingers or using animal-hair or vegetable-fiber brushes.



Paintings of stencilled hands by children and adults, Cueva de las Manos (Cave of the Hands), Santa Cruz, Argentina

“Whether in cave paintings or the latest uses of the Internet, human beings have always told their histories and truths through parable and fable.”

Beeban Kidron (born 1961), English film director